

Value-Driven Data Annotation (VDDA)

Recruitment Materials Package

1. Overview of Recruitment Strategy

This document presents all recruitment materials used in the VDDA study. Participants are recruited through two channels: (1) the Prolific academic crowdsourcing platform, and (2) supplementary outreach via email listservs and social media affiliated with the University of Toronto. All materials have been reviewed for compliance with U of T research ethics standards and Prolific's platform policies.

Recruitment targets approximately 100 participants across two datasets. For each dataset, four to five theoretically motivated lived-experience groups are recruited via Prolific pre-screener filters, alongside a random-baseline stratum (approximately 30 participants per dataset, no topical pre-screener applied).

Recruitment channel summary:

Primary: Prolific (targeted pre-screener + study listing). Supplementary: Email to U of T-affiliated listservs; posts on the research team's academic social media accounts (LinkedIn, X/Twitter). The supplementary channels direct interested participants to the Prolific listing; no data is collected outside the Prolific platform environment.

2. Prolific Study Listings

The following study listings are posted on Prolific. Each listing targets one lived-experience group via Prolific's pre-screener filters. The study description text is identical across all listings; only the pre-screener targeting differs. The full study description is reproduced once below, followed by the per-group screener specifications.

2.1 Full Prolific Study Description (shown to all participants)

How does your lived experience shape the way you read online content?

Prolific Study Title (as shown to participants)

We are researchers at the University of Toronto studying how people's personal backgrounds and lived experiences shape the way they interpret online posts about sensitive social topics.

In this study, you will:

- Have a short conversation with an AI assistant about your perspective on a topic (about 15-20 minutes). The AI will ask you open-ended questions — there are no right or wrong answers.
- Read a set of social media posts and give your interpretation of each one, along with a brief explanation of your reasoning (about 25-30 minutes).

Your interpretation — including any uncertainty — is exactly what we are studying. We are not testing you. We want to understand how your background shapes what you notice.

What topics will I be reading about?

Depending on which version of the study you are assigned to, you will read posts related to: (1) immigration, belonging, and national identity, or (2) chronic pain and invisible disability. You will be told which topic before you begin and can withdraw at any point.

What data is collected?

Your open-ended responses, your post interpretations, and ratings you provide. No identifying information beyond your Prolific ID is collected by the research team. All data is stored securely on University of Toronto systems.

Who is running this study?

This study is conducted by Sheza Munir (PhD student, Department of Computer Science) under the supervision of Dr. Ishtiaque Ahmed, University of Toronto.

Can I withdraw?

Yes, at any time and without penalty. If you withdraw after beginning the annotation phase, you will still receive compensation prorated to the portion completed.

Eligibility shown on Prolific:

See Section 2.2 for per-group specifications

Compensation:

CAD \$15.00 for approximately 45-50 minutes

2.2 Per-Group Prolific Pre-Screener Specifications

The table below specifies the Prolific pre-screener filters applied for each targeted group. All groups are recruited for the same study listing; screeners are applied at the platform level before participants see the listing.

Group ID	Group Label	Dataset	Prolific Screener Filter(s)	Target n
IB-G1	Recent immigrants (arrived within 10 years)	Immigration + Belonging	Country of birth $\neq$ country of residence; years in current country $\leq$ 10	10
IB-G2	Second-generation (born in country, parents born abroad)	Immigration + Belonging	Born in CA or US; at least one parent born outside CA/US (Prolific custom screener)	10
IB-G3	Immigration lawyers / policy advocates	Immigration + Belonging	Employment sector: Legal services or Policy/Government + custom screener: 'Does your work directly involve immigration law or immigration policy?'	10
IB-G4	Lifelong residents (no personal immigration experience)	Immigration + Belonging	Born in country of current residence; parents born in same country (custom screener)	10
IB-G5	Refugees / asylum seekers	Immigration + Belonging	Custom screener: 'Have you ever applied for asylum or refugee status in any country?'	10
IB-BL	Random baseline — no topical filter	Immigration + Belonging	No pre-screener applied beyond Prolific standard eligibility	10
CP-G1	People currently living with chronic pain or invisible disability	Chronic Pain	Custom screener: 'Do you currently live with chronic pain or an invisible disability (e.g., fibromyalgia, lupus, chronic back pain, migraine disorder)?'	10
CP-G2	Caregivers / close family members	Chronic Pain	Custom screener: 'Do you provide regular care or	10

			support to someone who lives with chronic pain or an invisible disability?'	
CP-G3	Medical professionals (doctors, nurses, physiotherapists)	Chronic Pain	Employment sector: Healthcare + custom screener: 'Is your current role a clinical or patient-facing medical role?'	10
CP-G4	Recovered from acute (not chronic) injury	Chronic Pain	Custom screener: 'Have you recovered from a significant acute injury or illness (one that fully resolved), but do NOT currently live with chronic pain?'	10
CP-BL	Random baseline — no topical filter	Chronic Pain	No pre-screener applied beyond Prolific standard eligibility	10

Note on custom screeners:

Prolific allows researchers to add custom screener questions visible only to participants who pass standard filters. Custom screener questions used in this study are single yes/no questions. Participants who answer 'no' are excluded from that group listing but remain eligible for the random baseline listing. Screener responses are not retained by the research team; they are managed entirely within Prolific's platform.

3. Supplementary Social Media Announcements

The following posts are used on the research team's academic social media accounts (LinkedIn and X/Twitter) to supplement Prolific recruitment. These posts do not collect data directly; they direct interested parties to the Prolific study listing. Individuals who contact the research team directly (e.g., by email) are directed to the Prolific listing and complete the study through that platform only.

3.1 LinkedIn Post

LinkedIn — Research Announcement

Calling for study participants: How does your lived experience shape the way you read online posts? We are researchers at the University of Toronto running a paid online study on how personal background and lived experience influence the interpretation of social media content. We are especially looking for people with connections to: • Immigration, belonging, or refugee experience • Chronic pain or invisible disability (as a patient, caregiver, or medical professional) The study takes approximately 45-50 minutes and pays CAD \$15. It is fully online, run through the Prolific platform. If you are eligible and interested, please participate through Prolific: [PROLIFIC STUDY LINK] Questions? Contact: sheza.munir@mail.utoronto.ca

[#ChronicPain](#) [#Immigration](#) [#PaidResearch](#) [#UofT](#) [#HCI](#) [#NLP](#) [#OnlineStudy](#)

3.2 X / Twitter Post (280 characters)

X / Twitter — Short announcement

Paid online study (CAD \$15, ~45 min) at @UofT: How does your lived experience shape how you read social media posts? Seeking participants with backgrounds in immigration/belonging or chronic pain. Fully remote, via Prolific [PROLIFIC STUDY LINK]

#PaidResearch #ChronicPain #ImmigrantStories #UofT

3.3 Academic Listserv / Email Announcement

The following email is sent to relevant U of T-affiliated listservs, including the Department of Computer Science graduate student listserv, the Faculty of Information listserv, and relevant student association lists where appropriate. It is also forwarded to known networks of HCI and NLP researchers who may be able to share with their own communities.

Subject: Paid Online Study — How Does Your Experience Shape How You Read Online Posts? (U of T)

Dear colleagues and community members,

We are researchers at the University of Toronto (Department of Computer Science) and are currently recruiting participants for a paid online study examining how lived experience shapes the interpretation of online content.

STUDY SUMMARY

Title: Value-Driven Data Annotation: Operationalizing Lived Experience in NLP Annotation Practices

Time required: Approximately 45-50 minutes

Compensation: CAD \$15.00

Format: Fully online, conducted through the Prolific platform

Ethics approval: University of Toronto REB

WHO WE ARE LOOKING FOR

We are particularly interested in hearing from people with:

- Personal or professional experience with immigration, belonging, or refugee issues
- Lived experience with chronic pain or invisible disability (as a patient, caregiver, or medical professional)
- No connection to either topic (as a comparison group)

WHAT THE STUDY INVOLVES

Participants will have a short conversation with an AI assistant about their perspective on a social topic, then read and interpret a set of real social media posts. There are no right or wrong answers — we are studying how different backgrounds lead to different readings of the same content.

HOW TO PARTICIPATE

The study is conducted entirely through Prolific. If you are interested, please visit the following link to check your eligibility and participate: [PROLIFIC STUDY LINK]

If you have questions about the study before deciding whether to participate, please contact: Sheza Munir, sheza.munir@mail.utoronto.ca

Thank you for your time and for considering sharing this with your networks.

Sheza Munir
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University of Toronto
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[Supervisor: Dr. Ishtiaque Ahmed, ishtiaque.ahmed@utoronto.ca]

4. Recruitment Safeguards and Ethical Considerations

4.1 Voluntary Participation

All recruitment materials make clear that participation is voluntary and that compensation will not be affected by withdrawal. No participant is contacted more than once by the research team through supplementary channels. The Prolific platform enforces a non-coercive design: participants choose to view and accept the study listing; there is no targeted direct messaging.

4.2 No Deception in Recruitment

All recruitment materials accurately describe the nature, duration, and purpose of the study. The involvement of an AI assistant in the elicitation phase is disclosed in the study listing. Participants are not told that their responses will be 'scored' (to avoid demand characteristics), but they are told their responses will be used to understand how background shapes interpretation, which is an accurate and complete description of the study's purpose.

4.3 Vulnerable Group Considerations

The Chronic Pain recruitment materials are designed to avoid framing participation as a form of advocacy or catharsis, which could create undue inducement for participants who are actively distressed. The study description specifies the topic plainly without emotionally charged framing. Participants who identify as currently living with chronic pain are the intended target of group CP-G1, but the study description does not imply that participation will benefit them medically or therapeutically.

For the Refugee / Asylum Seeker group (IB-G5), the custom screener question is phrased in past tense ('Have you ever applied...') to include people who have resolved their status and reduce participation by individuals in active, legally precarious situations. No recruitment materials are directed at community organizations that serve people with active asylum claims.

4.4 Compensation Justification

Compensation of CAD \$15.00 for approximately 45-50 minutes is set at approximately CAD \$18/hour, above Prolific's minimum rate of CAD \$12/hour. This rate was determined based on: (a) the cognitive effort involved in both the elicitation and annotation phases; (b) rates used in comparable HCI annotation studies at U of T and peer institutions; and (c) Ontario living wage considerations. The compensation is not so high as to constitute undue inducement for any of the target populations.

4.5 No Exclusion by Result of Screener

Participants who do not qualify for a targeted group listing remain eligible for the random-baseline listing. Prolific screener responses are not retained or linked to study data by the research team; they exist solely within Prolific's recruitment infrastructure and are used only to assign participants to the appropriate listing.

5. Contact Information for Participant Inquiries

Role	Contact
Principal Investigator (primary contact)	Sheza Munir, PhD Candidate Dept. of Computer Science, University of Toronto sheza.munir@mail.utoronto.ca
Faculty Supervisor	Dr. Ishtiaque Ahmed, Associate Professor Dept. of Computer Science, University of Toronto ishtiaque.ahmed@utoronto.ca
REB (for concerns about participant rights)	Office of Research Ethics, University of Toronto ethics.review@utoronto.ca Tel: +1 416 946-3273 McMurrich Building, 12 Queen's Park Crescent West, 2nd Floor, Toronto, ON M5S 1S8

All recruitment materials include the study's REB protocol number and the principal investigator's contact information. Participants are encouraged to contact the PI with any questions before deciding whether to participate. The REB contact is included in the consent form (submitted separately) for participants who wish to raise concerns about their rights.